

important it was to do well in school. When I went to college, he said, “Tom, you are going to feel like you’re going to jail. You can go out Friday night or Saturday night, but you can’t go out both, or else you won’t get ahead.” I really had in my mind that, at some point, I would study business. My plan was that I would get an MBA. I thought that if I could get both a chemical engineering degree and a business degree, then I could be a manager in a chemical company.

After my first two years of work, I decided to go to business school. I applied and got into Harvard. I got the impression from most of my classmates that their families were elated when they got into Harvard Business School. My father, however, was not happy at all when I got accepted. I was not even sure that I was going to go. Then word got out at my company that I had been accepted to Harvard Business School, and one of the vice presidents called and asked me out to lunch. I thought, *This guy never even acknowledged my existence, and now he calls to take me out to lunch just because I was accepted. Maybe I should go to this place after all.*

Your father was an educated guy; he was a veterinarian. Why was he so negative on your going to Harvard?

He was upset that I was leaving a job that was paying \$15,800 to go back to school. My father was a very tough guy. He didn’t start undergrad until his mid-twenties because he felt he had to stay home, work the family farm, and take care of his mother. My father measured almost everything in terms of money. During the summers, I would help my father on the farm, cutting timber and doing other stuff. He would take me down through the woods and teach me about trees. We came across this magnificent walnut tree. My father said with admiration, “Isn’t this a beautiful tree? It’s probably worth \$3,000.”

Not counting your dabbling with stocks as a child, when did you start investing in the stock market?

I never wanted to depend on my job for money. So I started investing from day one. From the start, I tried to give myself motivation to save money. My plan was to live on one-third of my income plus 3 percent of my net worth. The 3 percent of my net worth figure was based on the